

COUPONEX

MASTER OPERATIONS PLAYBOOK

India's Peer-to-Peer Digital Coupon Exchange Platform

COMPLETE GUIDE: BUILD • LAUNCH • MAINTAIN • SCALE

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SECTION 1 — COMPANY OVERVIEW & VISION

1.1 What is CouponEx?

CouponEx is India's first peer-to-peer (P2P) digital coupon exchange marketplace. It allows users who have unused discount coupons, promo codes, or gift vouchers — from brands like Swiggy, Zomato, Myntra, Amazon, Flipkart, and hundreds of others — to list and sell them to other buyers at a negotiated price below face value. Buyers save money; sellers recover value from coupons they would otherwise waste. CouponEx sits in the middle as a trusted escrow layer, verifying coupons, holding payment, and releasing funds only after a successful redemption.

1.2 The Problem We Solve

India generates hundreds of millions of coupons every month across e-commerce, food delivery, travel, and retail. A significant portion of these expire unused because:

- The user already completed the purchase the coupon was for
- The minimum spend is too high for a single buyer
- The user simply forgot
- The coupon was received as a gift from a brand the user doesn't use

There is currently no safe, organized marketplace for coupon resale in India. WhatsApp groups and Reddit threads exist but lack trust infrastructure, verification, dispute resolution, or legal compliance. CouponEx fills this exact gap.

1.3 Our Solution

CouponEx provides:

- A verified marketplace where sellers list coupons with proof of validity
- OCR-powered coupon scanning and AI-assisted verification via Google Vision API
- A 7-step escrow engine powered by Razorpay to protect both buyer and seller
- A dynamic pricing engine that suggests fair market rates based on demand and expiry
- A Trust Score system (0-100) that builds reputation for recurring users
- Mobile-first UX for both Android and iOS

1.4 Vision Statement

To become the most trusted coupon economy in India — where no discount ever goes to waste, and every user saves smarter.

1.5 Mission Statement

To build a fair, transparent, and fraud-resistant peer-to-peer marketplace that unlocks the dormant value locked inside India's billions of unused coupons.

1.6 Core Values

- Trust First: Every feature we build starts with asking 'How does this protect both parties?'
- Transparency: No hidden fees, no surprise deductions — all fees shown upfront
- Accessibility: Works on ₹5,000 phones with 3G connectivity
- Frugal Innovation: Indian-first design — built for price-sensitive power users

1.7 Target Market

Primary Users (Sellers): Working professionals in metro cities aged 22–35 who receive brand coupons through corporate benefits, credit card rewards, brand campaigns, or loyalty programs and cannot use all of them.

Primary Users (Buyers): Deal-seeking consumers, especially in Tier 1 and Tier 2 cities, who are comfortable buying digital goods from known platforms.

Secondary Market: Small businesses and resellers who buy coupons in bulk to power their own operations.

1.8 Market Size (India)

Metric	Target	Timeline
Indian coupon user base	~120 million active users	2025 estimate
Annual value of unused coupons	~₹8,000 crore+	Industry estimate
Digital coupon market CAGR	~18% per year	2024–2028 forecast
Total Addressable Market (TAM)	₹8,000 crore	Yr 1 target segment
Serviceable Market (SAM)	₹800 crore	Metro + Tier 2 cities
Realistic Obtainable Market	₹50 crore	Year 3 target

(SOM)

1.9 Competitive Landscape

Competitor / Alternative	Our Advantage Over Them
WhatsApp Groups / Reddit	No verification, no escrow, no dispute resolution — we have all three
CouponDunia / GrabOn (aggregators)	They list brand coupons, not user-generated P2P listings
OLX / Quikr (general classifieds)	No category specialization, no coupon OCR, no escrowed transactions
Manual coupon Facebook groups	No trust scoring, rampant fraud — we solve this structurally
No direct Indian P2P competitor	We are first-mover in this niche — timing is our moat

1.10 Legal Entity & Compliance

- Register as a Private Limited Company under Companies Act 2013 (MCA portal)
- Apply for DPIIT Startup India recognition for tax benefits and self-certification
- Obtain FSSAI if food/restaurant coupons are handled (check classification)
- GST registration (mandatory once turnover crosses ₹20 lakh)
- RBI Payment Aggregator guidelines compliance (work with Razorpay as licensed PA)
- Draft Terms of Service, Privacy Policy, and Coupon Listing Policy

SECTION 2 — PRODUCT & TECHNOLOGY

2.1 Core Product Architecture

CouponEx is built as a three-layer system:

- Mobile App (React Native / Expo) — Primary user surface for buyers and sellers
- Web App (React.js / Vite) — Secondary surface, also used for admin dashboards
- Backend API (Node.js / Express) — RESTful API powering all business logic
- Database (MongoDB Atlas) — Document store for users, coupons, transactions
- Cloud (AWS — EC2, S3, CloudFront, SES) — Hosting, storage, CDN, email
- Payment (Razorpay) — Escrow hold, payout, refund flows
- OCR (Google Vision API) — Coupon image verification

2.2 The 7-Step Escrow Lifecycle

This is the heart of CouponEx's trust mechanism. Every transaction follows these steps without exception:

1. Seller lists coupon — uploads image/code, sets asking price, sets expiry date
2. System verification — Google Vision OCR reads coupon details, AI checks for known fraud patterns, manual review queue for flagged coupons
3. Buyer places order — pays via Razorpay; funds are held in escrow, not released to seller yet
4. Seller reveals full coupon code — only after buyer's payment is confirmed in escrow
5. Buyer attempts redemption — buyer has a defined window (e.g. 24–48 hours) to redeem and confirm or raise a dispute
6. Successful redemption — buyer clicks 'Confirm Redemption'; funds are released to seller minus platform commission
7. Dispute resolution — if buyer reports failure, admin reviews OCR records, usage logs, and decides payout or refund

2.3 Trust Score Engine

Every user has a Trust Score from 0 to 100 calculated dynamically. Scores affect listing visibility, transaction limits, and fee tiers.

Factor	Impact on Trust Score
Successful transactions completed	+5 points per transaction
Dispute raised against user	-15 points per unresolved dispute

Email + phone + Aadhaar verification	+10 points per tier verified
Coupon verification pass rate	+3 per passing coupon, -8 per failed one
Response time to buyer queries	+2 for < 1hr response avg
Account age (longevity)	+1 per 30 days active use

2.4 Dynamic Pricing Engine

The pricing engine suggests a fair listing price to sellers based on:

- Days until coupon expiry (closer = lower suggested price)
- Historical transaction prices for similar coupons
- Current demand (number of active buyer searches for that brand/category)
- Face value of the coupon
- Seller's Trust Score (higher score = can command higher price)

Sellers are free to override the suggestion but are shown how their price compares to market median.

2.5 Mobile App — Key Screens

- Onboarding: Phone OTP signup, KYC-lite (name + selfie optional for high limits), Trust Score baseline
- Home Feed: Curated coupon deals sorted by brand, discount %, expiry, Trust Score of seller
- Sell Flow: Camera scan or manual entry, OCR auto-fill, pricing suggestion, listing confirmation
- Buy Flow: Browse/search, coupon detail, escrow checkout, redemption timer, confirm/dispute
- Wallet: Razorpay credits balance, transaction history, pending payouts, refund status
- Trust Profile: Public profile showing Trust Score badge, transaction history, reviews
- Notifications: Push notifications for order status, coupon expiry warnings, disputes

2.6 Admin Dashboard (Web App)

- User management: KYC review, account suspension, Trust Score overrides
- Coupon moderation queue: AI-flagged coupons pending human review
- Transaction monitoring: Real-time escrow status, stuck transactions, manual release
- Dispute resolution center: Case details, evidence (OCR records, chat logs), ruling tools
- Analytics: GMV, take rate, category breakdown, daily active users, churn
- Finance: Payout scheduling, settlement reconciliation, GST reports

2.7 Tech Stack Summary

Layer	Technology Choices
Mobile Frontend	React Native + Expo (iOS and Android from one codebase)
Web Frontend	React.js + Vite (fast builds, modern tooling)
Backend API	Node.js + Express.js (REST API)
Database	MongoDB Atlas (M10 cluster to start, auto-scale)
File Storage	AWS S3 (coupon images, KYC docs)
CDN	AWS CloudFront (image delivery at speed)
Payments	Razorpay Route (escrow, payouts, refunds)
OCR / Vision	Google Cloud Vision API
Authentication	JWT tokens + Firebase Auth (OTP via SMS)
Email	AWS SES (transactional emails)
Hosting	AWS EC2 (t3.medium to start) + Nginx reverse proxy
Monitoring	Sentry (errors) + AWS CloudWatch (infra)
CI/CD	GitHub Actions (automated build + deploy pipeline)
Security	AES-256 encryption for stored coupon codes; HTTPS everywhere

SECTION 3 — ENGINEERING & DEVELOPMENT

3.1 Department Role

Engineering is the department that designs, builds, tests, deploys, and maintains every line of code that makes CouponEx work. They translate the product requirements into working software and are responsible for system reliability, performance, security, and scalability.

3.2 Team Structure

Role	Responsibilities
CTO / Lead Engineer	Architecture decisions, code review standards, hiring engineers, technical roadmap
Backend Engineer (×2)	API development, database schemas, escrow logic, integrations
Frontend Engineer — Web (×1)	React web app, admin dashboard, responsive design
Mobile Engineer (×2)	React Native app, push notifications, camera/OCR integration
DevOps Engineer (×1)	AWS infrastructure, CI/CD pipelines, monitoring, cost optimization
QA Engineer (×1)	Test plans, automated tests, bug triage, release sign-off
Security Engineer (part-time/contract)	Pen testing, security audits, vulnerability patches

3.3 Development Process

- Two-week sprints using Agile/Scrum methodology
- Jira or Linear for ticket management and sprint planning
- GitHub for all version control — trunk-based development with feature flags
- Pull Request (PR) review policy: minimum 2 engineer approvals before merge
- Automated tests run on every PR via GitHub Actions
- Staging environment for QA, production environment for live users
- Feature flags to safely ship code to a % of users before full rollout
- Post-mortems for every P0/P1 incident within 48 hours of resolution

3.4 Build Phases

Phase 1 — MVP (Months 1–4)

- User auth (OTP login), basic profile, Trust Score calculation
- Coupon listing flow: manual entry + image upload + OCR read
- Escrow checkout: Razorpay integration, payment hold
- 7-step transaction lifecycle — full escrow engine
- Basic dispute flag — admin email notification
- Android app on Play Store (internal testing first)
- Web admin dashboard — basic moderation and transaction monitor

Phase 2 — Growth (Months 5–8)

- iOS app on App Store
- Dynamic pricing engine V1
- Trust Score V2 — more signals, badge tiers (Bronze / Silver / Gold)
- In-app chat between buyer and seller (pre-escrow clarifications only)
- Wallet with Razorpay credits — instant payouts for high-trust sellers
- Push notifications (order status, expiry warnings)
- Brand coupon catalog — direct brand partnerships starting

Phase 3 — Scale (Months 9–18)

- AI-powered coupon fraud detection (ML model trained on transaction history)
- Group buy feature — pool together to hit minimum spend
- Subscription tier for power users (CouponEx Pro)
- API for brand partners — brands push coupons directly into the marketplace
- Multi-language support: Hindi, Kannada, Tamil, Telugu
- Performance optimization for Tier 3 / low-bandwidth users

3.5 Engineering KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
API uptime	99.9% (< 8.7hrs downtime/year)	From launch
API response time (p95)	< 400ms	Month 2
App crash rate	< 0.5%	Month 1
Deployment frequency	2x per week minimum	Month 3
Bug resolution time (P1)	< 4 hours	From launch

Test coverage	> 70% unit + integration	Month 4
OCR accuracy	> 92% correct reads	Month 2
Escrow transaction success rate	> 99.5%	Month 1

3.6 Infrastructure Cost Estimate (Monthly)

Resource	Estimated Monthly Cost
AWS EC2 (t3.medium × 2)	₹6,000/month
MongoDB Atlas (M10)	₹4,500/month
AWS S3 + CloudFront	₹1,500/month
Google Vision API	₹2,000/month (first 1000 calls free)
Firebase Auth (OTP)	₹1,000/month
AWS SES (email)	₹500/month
GitHub + Jira/Linear	₹2,000/month
Sentry + monitoring	₹1,500/month
Total (approx)	~₹19,000/month (scales with usage)

SECTION 4 — PRODUCT MANAGEMENT

4.1 Department Role

Product Management (PM) is the connective tissue of CouponEx. The PM function is responsible for defining what gets built, in what order, and why. PMs gather insights from users, business needs, and technical constraints — and translate these into a clear roadmap that the engineering team executes.

4.2 Team Structure

Role	Responsibilities
Head of Product (Founder / CPO)	Overall product vision, roadmap prioritization, stakeholder alignment
Product Manager — Core Platform	Escrow engine, Trust Score, listing flow, dispute resolution
Product Manager — Growth	Referral programs, notifications, retention loops, A/B testing
UX Designer (×1–2)	User research, wireframes, Figma prototypes, usability testing
Product Analyst	Funnel analysis, feature instrumentation, North Star metric tracking

4.3 Product Frameworks

North Star Metric

Gross Merchandise Value (GMV) of successfully completed coupon transactions per month. This single number captures whether buyers are finding value (transactions happening), sellers are satisfied (coupons moving), and the platform is healthy (not just listing, but completing).

AARRR Funnel for CouponEx

- Acquisition: New installs from app stores, referrals, social ads
- Activation: First coupon listed OR first coupon purchased within 7 days of signup
- Retention: User returns to list/buy within 30 days of first transaction
- Referral: User refers at least 1 friend who completes a transaction
- Revenue: Platform commission earned per completed GMV

4.4 Roadmap Prioritization Framework

Use the RICE scoring model for all feature requests:

- Reach — How many users does this feature impact per quarter?
- Impact — On a scale of 0.25x to 3x, how much does it move the North Star?
- Confidence — How certain are we this will work? (100% = strong evidence, 50% = guess)
- Effort — How many engineer-weeks does it take?

RICE Score = (Reach × Impact × Confidence) / Effort — build highest score features first.

4.5 Product KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
Monthly GMV	₹10 lakh (Month 6), ₹1 crore (Month 12)	Month 6 / 12
Monthly Active Users (MAU)	10,000 (Month 6), 100,000 (Month 18)	Months 6 / 18
Activation rate (first transaction)	> 25% of signups	Month 3
Day-30 retention	> 35%	Month 4
Dispute rate	< 3% of transactions	Month 2
Average transaction value	₹200–₹600	Month 3
NPS (Net Promoter Score)	> 45	Month 6
App store rating	> 4.2 stars	Month 3

4.6 User Research Process

- Monthly 30-minute user interviews with 10 active users (5 buyers, 5 sellers)
- In-app survey on every completed transaction (3-question max)
- Weekly review of 1-star app store reviews — tagged by issue type
- Quarterly usability testing sessions with new users from Bengaluru / Mumbai
- Feature-level instrumentation via Mixpanel or Amplitude — track every tap, every drop-off

SECTION 5 — FINANCE & BUSINESS MODEL

5.1 Department Role

The Finance department manages CouponEx's money — how it earns, how it spends, how it plans, and how it reports. In the early stage, the founder handles finance with support from a CA. As the company scales, a CFO role is added.

5.2 Revenue Model

Stream 1: Platform Commission

CouponEx takes a percentage of every successful transaction as a commission. The commission is deducted from the seller's payout automatically via Razorpay Route before settlement.

Seller Trust Score Tier	Commission Rate
Bronze (0–39)	12% of transaction value
Silver (40–69)	9% of transaction value
Gold (70–100)	6% of transaction value

Stream 2: Premium Listing Boost

Sellers can pay ₹19–₹49 to have their coupon listing featured at the top of category pages for 24–72 hours. This is a self-serve PPC model.

Stream 3: CouponEx Pro Subscription

Power users who transact frequently can subscribe for ₹99/month and receive: reduced commission (5% flat), priority dispute resolution, early access to brand coupons, and a Pro badge.

Stream 4: Brand Coupon Campaigns

Brands can pay CouponEx a fixed campaign fee to distribute coupons directly to verified users on the platform. This is a B2B revenue line that scales with user base.

Stream 5: Interest on Escrow Float

At scale, CouponEx holds meaningful funds in escrow at any given time. Negotiating a sweep account with Razorpay or a bank to earn interest on this float becomes a passive income stream.

5.3 Financial Projections

Metric	Target	Timeline
Monthly GMV (Month 6)	₹10,00,000	₹90,000 revenue @ 9% avg
Monthly GMV (Month 12)	₹1,00,00,000	₹9,00,000 revenue
Monthly GMV (Month 18)	₹5,00,00,000	₹35,00,000 revenue
Break-even point	₹30–40 lakh monthly GMV	Approx Month 10–12
Year 1 revenue target	₹60–75 lakh	All streams combined
Year 2 revenue target	₹3–5 crore	Post product-market fit

5.4 Cost Structure (Year 1)

Cost Category	Annual Estimate
Salaries (core team of 8–10)	₹60–80 lakh
Infrastructure (AWS, APIs, tools)	₹2.5–4 lakh
Marketing & user acquisition	₹15–25 lakh
Legal & compliance	₹2–4 lakh
Office / co-working space	₹3–5 lakh
Contingency buffer (10%)	₹8–12 lakh
Total burn (Year 1)	₹90 lakh – ₹1.3 crore

5.5 Funding Strategy

Bootstrapped Phase (Months 1–4)

- Founder personal capital + angel contribution for MVP build
- Target: ₹15–25 lakh to reach a testable MVP with first 500 users

Seed Round (Months 4–8)

- Target raise: ₹50 lakh – ₹1.5 crore
- Sources: Startup India Seed Fund Scheme (SISFS), angel networks (LetsVenture, AngelList India)
- Investors to target: 100X.VC (cheque sizes of ₹25–50 lakh), Antler India
- Use of funds: Team expansion, marketing, infrastructure scaling, legal

Series A (Month 18–24)

- Target raise: ₹5–15 crore
- Triggered by: Consistent GMV growth, 50,000+ MAU, clear unit economics

- Investors: Tier-1 Indian VCs (Blume Ventures, Elevation Capital, Stellaris)

5.6 Unit Economics

Metric	Target
Customer Acquisition Cost (CAC)	< ₹80 per verified user
Lifetime Value (LTV)	> ₹600 over 12 months for active user
LTV:CAC Ratio	> 7:1 (target healthy SaaS/marketplace benchmark)
Gross Margin	> 70% (after Razorpay fees and Google Vision cost)
Payback Period	< 4 months on CAC
Average Revenue Per User (ARPU)	₹50–150/month for active users

5.7 Finance Team Responsibilities

- Monthly P&L reporting to founders and investors
- GST filing and compliance (monthly GSTR-1, GSTR-3B)
- TDS deductions on contractor payouts
- Payroll processing and PF/ESI compliance (once team exceeds 10)
- Cash flow forecasting — minimum 6-month runway visibility at all times
- Annual statutory audit by certified CA
- Investor reporting pack — MIS (Monthly Information Statement) to all investors
- Budget ownership for each department — quarterly re-forecasting

SECTION 6 — MARKETING & GROWTH

6.1 Department Role

The Marketing and Growth department is responsible for making CouponEx visible, desirable, and viral. Their goal is to acquire users at the lowest possible cost and retain them with engaging content and product-led loops.

6.2 Team Structure

Role	Responsibilities
Head of Marketing / Growth	Strategy, brand, budget ownership, channel mix
Performance Marketing Manager	Paid campaigns — Google Ads, Meta Ads, attribution tracking
Content Creator / Social Media	Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, deal posts, brand voice
SEO Specialist	Blog content, app store optimization (ASO), backlink building
Community Manager	WhatsApp/Telegram communities, Reddit, Discord for coupon enthusiasts
Brand Partnerships Manager	Outreach to brands for campaign tie-ups

6.3 Go-To-Market Strategy

Phase 1 — Bengaluru-First Launch (Months 1–3)

CouponEx launches exclusively in Bengaluru. This is intentional — it allows the team to control supply, handle customer support, and learn fast before scaling. Bengaluru is ideal as it is India's tech capital with the highest density of deal-savvy, coupon-receiving professionals.

- Target: 1,000 verified users in first 60 days
- Channels: LinkedIn posts by founder, WhatsApp college/office groups, tech community Slack groups
- Incentive: First 100 sellers get 0% commission for first 3 months
- First 100 buyers get ₹50 cashback on first completed transaction

Phase 2 — Metro Expansion (Months 4–8)

- Expand to Mumbai, Delhi-NCR, Hyderabad, Pune, Chennai
- Launch performance marketing with ₹50,000/month paid budget

- Referral program: ₹30 credited to both referrer and referee on first transaction
- College ambassador program: 20 brand ambassadors across top engineering / MBA colleges
- Influencer micro-campaigns: Personal finance and deal influencers on Instagram/YouTube

Phase 3 — National Scale (Months 9–18)

- Pan-India launch with Tier 2/3 city focus
- Regional language content: Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada
- OTT/podcast advertising targeting deal-seeking audiences
- Corporate tie-ups: Partner with HR departments to offer CouponEx as an employee benefit

6.4 Content Marketing Strategy

- Weekly 'Deal Digest' newsletter — top 10 coupons available this week on CouponEx
- Instagram Reels: Short tutorials ('How to sell your Swiggy coupon in 60 seconds')
- YouTube: Educational content on smart saving, coupon stacking, financial frugality
- SEO Blog: Targeting high-intent search terms like 'sell Zomato coupon', 'buy Myntra promo code'
- Case studies: Feature real user stories ('How Priya saved ₹5,000 last month using CouponEx')
- Reddit presence in r/IndiaFinance, r/DesiSavings — authentic, non-promotional posts first

6.5 Viral / Product-Led Growth Loops

CouponEx is designed so that the act of saving money is inherently shareable:

- Share-a-deal: Buyers can share a coupon listing to friends via WhatsApp with a personalized link
- Savings milestone cards: 'You saved ₹2,000 this month with CouponEx!' — shareable on Instagram Stories
- Leaderboard: Top 10 savers / sellers of the month featured on app home screen
- Referral engine: Both-sided reward — tracked via unique referral code per user

6.6 Marketing KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
App installs (Month 3)	5,000 installs	Month 3
App installs (Month 12)	1,00,000 installs	Month 12
CAC (paid channel)	< ₹120 per install	Month 3 onward
Referral conversion rate	> 15% of referred users complete transaction	Month 4
Social media followers	10,000 Instagram by Month 6	Month 6

Monthly blog organic traffic	20,000 sessions by Month 9	Month 9
Email open rate	> 28% (industry avg is 22%)	Month 3
Paid ROAS	> 4x return on ad spend	Month 5

SECTION 7 — SALES & PARTNERSHIPS

7.1 Department Role

Sales and Partnerships focuses on the B2B revenue side of CouponEx — bringing brands, corporate clients, and strategic partners onto the platform. While Marketing brings in consumers, Sales brings in business-level relationships that create supply, credibility, and recurring revenue.

7.2 Team Structure

Role	Responsibilities
Head of Sales / BD	B2B pipeline, brand outreach, partnership negotiations, revenue targets
Brand Partnerships Executive	Direct outreach to e-commerce, food delivery, travel, retail brands
Corporate Sales Executive	HR/benefits packages — selling CouponEx as employee benefit to companies
Account Manager	Ongoing relationship management with brand partners post-signing

7.3 Brand Partnerships

Brands benefit from CouponEx in two ways: their coupons circulate longer (even unused ones find buyers), and they can run targeted distribution campaigns to CouponEx's verified, deal-seeking user base. The sales pitch to a brand:

- 'Your coupons currently expire unused and generate zero revenue. On CouponEx, they get a second life — and you can optionally receive analytics on redemption patterns.'
- 'We can run a targeted campaign where our 10,000 verified savers in Bengaluru receive exclusive discounts from your brand this week.'

Target brand categories for Year 1: E-commerce (Flipkart, Meesho), Food delivery (Zomato, Swiggy), OTT/Entertainment (Netflix, Amazon Prime, Zee5), Travel (MakeMyTrip, Ixigo), Fashion (Myntra, Ajio), Fintech (Paytm, PhonePe cashback).

7.4 Corporate Partnerships

Large IT companies, startups, and BPOs in Bengaluru offer employee benefits packages. CouponEx can be included as a platform benefit — the company pays a small per-seat fee (₹30–₹80 per employee per month) and all employees get CouponEx Pro status.

- Target companies: 50-person to 500-person tech startups in Bengaluru, Mumbai, Hyderabad
- Pitch: 'Give your employees an extra ₹500–₹1000 in savings per month at zero cost to you'
- Year 1 target: 5 corporate clients with average 200 employees = 1,000 Pro subscribers

7.5 Technology Partnerships

- Razorpay: Deep partnership for escrow, instant settlement, credits — negotiate lower MDR
- Google Cloud: Partner program for startups — potential Vision API credits
- AWS Activate: Startup credits program for free/discounted infrastructure
- Expo / React Native ecosystem: Community contributor status for reach among developers

7.6 Sales KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
Brand partnerships signed (Year 1)	15–20 brands	Month 12
Corporate accounts (Year 1)	5 accounts	Month 12
B2B revenue contribution	20% of total revenue	Month 18
Brand campaign GMV contribution	₹50 lakh+	Month 18
Outreach to close rate	> 20% (brand outreach)	Month 6

SECTION 8 — OPERATIONS & CUSTOMER SUPPORT

8.1 Department Role

Operations ensures that day-to-day activities run smoothly, on time, and at scale. Customer Support is the frontline for users — handling disputes, complaints, refunds, and general queries. For a trust-based marketplace like CouponEx, responsive and fair support is a core competitive advantage.

8.2 Customer Support Structure

Role	Responsibilities
Head of Operations	Org-wide processes, SLA ownership, escalation policy, vendor management
Customer Support Lead	Support team management, quality assurance, policy writing
Support Agent (Tier 1, ×2–3)	First response to buyer/seller queries via in-app chat and email
Dispute Resolution Specialist (×1)	Deep review of escrow disputes — rules on refund/release
Trust & Safety Analyst (×1)	Account fraud detection, ban enforcement, fake coupon investigation

8.3 Support Channels

- In-app live chat (primary) — powered by Intercom or Freshchat
- Email support: support@couponex.in (target < 4-hour first response)
- WhatsApp Business (for high-priority disputes)
- Help Centre / FAQ (self-serve): Covers top 30 user questions, reduces ticket volume by 40%

8.4 Dispute Resolution Process

8. Buyer raises a dispute within the redemption window (24–48 hrs)
9. Escrow is automatically frozen — funds not released to seller
10. Support agent collects evidence: OCR records, screenshots, chat history, redemption attempt timestamp
11. Dispute Specialist reviews — attempts to contact seller within 4 hours
12. If seller provides proof of valid code and buyer error: release funds to seller
13. If coupon was expired or fraudulent: full refund to buyer, Trust Score penalty to seller

14. If ambiguous: admin override, partial refund may apply, case documented
15. Decision communicated to both parties within 24 hours of dispute being raised

8.5 Operational Processes

- Daily: Review moderation queue (coupons flagged by AI for manual check)
- Daily: Clear escrow transactions that have passed 48-hour window without dispute
- Weekly: Review top dispute cases — identify patterns of seller fraud or buyer misuse
- Weekly: Update Help Centre with new FAQ based on week's top queries
- Monthly: Generate operations report — average resolution time, dispute rate by category, CSAT
- Monthly: Review and update coupon category policies (new brands, new coupon types)

8.6 Operations KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
First response time (Tier 1)	< 2 hours	Month 2
Dispute resolution time	< 24 hours from filing	Month 2
CSAT (Customer Satisfaction Score)	> 85%	Month 3
Dispute rate	< 3% of all transactions	Month 3
Escalation rate to Tier 2	< 15% of all tickets	Month 4
Fraudulent coupon rate	< 0.5% of listings	Month 3
Help Centre deflection rate	> 40% (queries self-served)	Month 4

SECTION 9 — LEGAL & COMPLIANCE

9.1 Department Role

Legal and Compliance protects CouponEx from regulatory risk, ensures the platform operates within Indian law, manages platform policies, handles intellectual property, and provides legal support for partnerships and contracts.

9.2 Team Structure

Role	Responsibilities
Legal Counsel (Retainer/Contract)	Corporate law, regulatory filings, vendor contracts, dispute escalations
Compliance Officer (Part-time)	RBI PA guidelines, Data Protection compliance, GST compliance
Policy Manager	Platform policies: ToS, Privacy Policy, Coupon Listing Policy, Refund Policy

9.3 Company Formation Checklist

16. Incorporate as Private Limited Company — MCA portal, ₹10,000–₹15,000 via CS
17. DPIIT Registration — Startup India recognition (free) — enables tax benefits
18. Trademark registration for 'CouponEx' brand name and logo — IP India portal
19. GST Registration — mandatory once turnover crosses ₹20 lakh
20. Open business current account — preferred: HDFC SmartUp or RazorpayX
21. Razorpay account setup — KYC for Payment Aggregator compliance
22. Domain + brand assets secured: couponex.in, all social handles
23. Founders Agreement signed between co-founders — equity split, vesting schedule
24. Employee Stock Option Plan (ESOP) pool created — 10–15% of equity

9.4 Key Legal Documents Required

- Terms of Service — defines platform rules, user obligations, liability limits
- Privacy Policy — DPDP Act (India 2023) compliant — data collected, how used, user rights
- Coupon Listing Policy — what can and cannot be listed, fraud definitions, suspension rules
- Refund and Dispute Policy — timelines, conditions, escalation paths
- Escrow Terms — what triggers hold, release, refund; who has authority

- Seller Agreement — for brand partners and high-volume sellers
- NDA Template — for employee/contractor confidentiality
- Employment Contracts — compliant with Indian labour law (fixed-term and permanent)

9.5 Regulatory Compliance

- RBI Payment Aggregator Guidelines: Since CouponEx holds funds in escrow, must operate under a licensed PA (Razorpay). Review RBI circular RBI/DPSS/2020-21/97 to confirm requirements.
- Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 (DPDP): Consent-first data collection, data minimization, user rights to delete data — appoint a Data Fiduciary
- Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules 2020: Mandatory grievance officer, 48-hour complaint acknowledgement, clear refund policy
- Income Tax / TDS: TDS on payments above ₹5,000 per transaction to sellers (Section 194-O)
- GST on platform commission: GST must be charged on commission revenue and filed monthly
- FSSAI (if applicable): If Zomato/Swiggy food coupons are listed — check if platform falls under FSSAI notification scope

9.6 Legal KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
Company incorporation	Done before first user acquisition	Month 1
DPIIT registration	Within 30 days of incorporation	Month 1
All platform policies live	Before public launch	Month 3
Trademark filing	Month 1 (application filed)	Month 1
First legal audit	Month 6	Month 6
DPDP compliance review	Every 6 months	Ongoing

SECTION 10 — HUMAN RESOURCES & HIRING

10.1 Department Role

HR is responsible for finding the right people, bringing them in, keeping them motivated and growing, and maintaining a healthy company culture. In a startup, every bad hire is costly — HR's job is to build a team that can outperform companies 10x their size.

10.2 Hiring Roadmap

Pre-Seed / MVP Phase (Month 1–4): Core Technical Team

- CTO / Lead Full-Stack Engineer (co-founder level if possible)
- Backend Engineer (Node.js + MongoDB)
- React Native Mobile Engineer
- Part-time UX Designer
- Part-time CA / Finance consultant

Seed Phase (Month 4–9): Growth Team

- Head of Marketing / Growth
- Frontend Web Engineer
- Customer Support Lead
- Product Manager
- DevOps Engineer

Growth Phase (Month 9–18): Scale Team

- QA Engineer
- Data Analyst
- Brand Partnerships Manager
- Additional Backend + Mobile Engineers (×2 each)
- Trust & Safety Analyst
- HR Manager (full-time, once team > 15 people)

10.3 Hiring Process

25. Role definition — JD written by hiring manager, approved by founder

26. Sourcing — LinkedIn, AngelList, Internshala (for freshers), IIT/NIT campus placements
27. Application review — 30-minute async take-home assignment to filter serious candidates
28. Technical round — 1-hour live coding / portfolio review (for engineers), case study (for PMs/marketers)
29. Culture fit round — 30-minute conversation with founder or senior team member
30. Reference checks — 2 professional references required before offer
31. Offer — CTC breakdown, ESOP grant, joining date, notice period negotiation

10.4 Compensation Philosophy

- Below-market cash CTC (15–20% below established company benchmarks) compensated by meaningful ESOP grants
- ESOP pool: 10–15% of fully diluted equity, 4-year vesting with 1-year cliff
- Annual performance review with salary corrections
- Learning and development budget: ₹10,000–₹20,000 per employee per year
- Health insurance from Day 1 (group policy, covers employee + family)
- Flexible work policy — hybrid model, outcome-based not hours-based

10.5 Culture Principles

- Owner Mentality: Every team member acts like a co-founder, not an employee
- Speed with Quality: We move fast but not at the cost of user trust
- No Silos: Engineering, product, and support share a common Slack workspace and weekly all-hands
- Psychological Safety: Mistakes acknowledged openly, blame-free post-mortems
- Frugality: We spend money where it creates user value, not for optics

10.6 HR KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
Time to hire (technical roles)	< 30 days from posting	Ongoing
Offer acceptance rate	> 75%	Month 6
3-month employee retention	> 90%	Ongoing
eNPS (Employee NPS)	> 40	First survey at Month 6
ESOP participation rate	> 80% of team	Month 6

SECTION 11 — DATA, ANALYTICS & AI

11.1 Department Role

Data, Analytics and AI is the intelligence layer of CouponEx. This team collects, processes, and interprets data to help every other department make better decisions. They also develop the AI-driven features that make CouponEx smarter over time — fraud detection, pricing, personalization.

11.2 Team Structure

Role	Responsibilities
Head of Data / Data Lead	Data architecture, tooling, governance, team management
Data Engineer	ETL pipelines, data warehouse, event streaming
Product/Business Analyst	Funnel analysis, A/B test analysis, dashboards, business reporting
ML Engineer (hire at Month 9+)	Fraud detection model, pricing model, recommendation engine

11.3 Data Architecture

- Event tracking: Every user action (tap, scroll, purchase, dispute) logged as an event in Amplitude or Mixpanel
- Data warehouse: AWS Redshift or BigQuery for historical analysis
- ETL: dbt (data build tool) for transforming raw event data into analytics-ready tables
- BI dashboards: Metabase or Looker Studio for real-time business metrics visible to all departments
- Real-time monitoring: AWS CloudWatch + custom Grafana dashboards for infra and transaction health

11.4 Key Analytics Use Cases

- Funnel analysis: Drop-off rate at each step of listing and purchase flows
- Cohort analysis: Day-1, Day-7, Day-30, Day-90 retention by acquisition channel and join date
- Category performance: Which coupon categories generate most GMV, highest disputes, fastest sell-through
- Trust Score calibration: Statistical validation that higher Trust Scores correlate with lower dispute rates

- Pricing elasticity: Does higher suggested price reduce sell-through? By how much?
- Fraud pattern detection: Clustering of fraud signals — new account + bulk listings + high-value coupons

11.5 AI Roadmap

Phase 1 (From MVP): Rule-Based Systems

- OCR + regex rule engine: Flags coupons whose text doesn't match expected brand coupon formats
- Price anomaly detection: Flags listings priced > 3× market median

Phase 2 (Month 6–9): Statistical ML

- Fraud scoring model: Logistic regression on account + listing features to score fraud probability
- Demand forecasting: Time-series model predicting demand for brand/category — feeds pricing engine

Phase 3 (Month 12+): Deep Learning / LLM

- Image fraud detection: CNN model trained on real vs fraudulent coupon screenshots
- Support auto-resolution: LLM-powered first-pass dispute analysis to suggest ruling to agents
- Personalized feed: Collaborative filtering recommending coupons based on user's past purchases

11.6 Data KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
Fraud detection precision	> 90% (minimize false positives)	Month 9
Fraud detection recall	> 80% (catch most real fraud)	Month 9
Dashboard data freshness	< 1-hour lag on live metrics	Month 4
A/B test cadence	> 3 experiments/month running	Month 5
OCR auto-fill accuracy	> 92%	Month 2

SECTION 12 — SECURITY & TRUST

12.1 Why Security is a First-Class Department

CouponEx handles user identity, payments, and proprietary coupon codes. A single breach or fraud scandal can destroy the trust that took months to build. Security is not an afterthought — it's woven into every layer of the platform from Day 1.

12.2 Security Architecture

Data at Rest

- Coupon codes encrypted using AES-256 before being stored in MongoDB
- PII (phone numbers, Aadhaar IDs) tokenized — never stored in raw form in application database
- MongoDB Atlas encryption at rest enabled by default on M10+ clusters

Data in Transit

- HTTPS everywhere — TLS 1.3 enforced across all endpoints
- API keys never exposed in frontend code — all secrets in AWS Secrets Manager
- JWT tokens: 15-minute access token + 7-day refresh token with rotation

Application Security

- OWASP Top 10 checklist reviewed for every major release
- SQL/NoSQL injection prevention via parameterized queries and input validation
- Rate limiting on all API endpoints — especially on login (max 5 attempts, then lockout)
- CORS policy strictly configured — only known frontend origins allowed
- Dependency scanning: npm audit + GitHub Dependabot for vulnerability alerts

12.3 Trust & Safety Policies

- Zero-tolerance policy for fake coupon listings: permanent ban on first confirmed offense
- Graduated suspension: warnings → temporary ban → permanent ban for repeat violations
- Seller verification tiers: Basic (phone OTP only) vs Verified (Aadhaar + selfie match)
- IP velocity checks: Multiple new accounts from one IP flagged for review
- Device fingerprinting: Returning banned users on new accounts can be detected
- Coupon code uniqueness check: Same code cannot be listed by two different sellers simultaneously

12.4 Incident Response Plan

- 32. Detection: Automated alert via Sentry / CloudWatch, or user report
- 33. Triage: On-call engineer assesses severity in < 15 minutes
- 34. Containment: Disable affected feature via feature flag, block affected IPs
- 35. Communication: Notify affected users within 2 hours if data involved
- 36. Root Cause Analysis: Full post-mortem within 48 hours
- 37. Remediation: Patch deployed, security controls tightened
- 38. Reporting: If user data exposed, notify CERT-In within 6 hours per Indian law

12.5 Security KPIs

Metric	Target	Timeline
External pen test	Every 6 months	Month 6, 12, 18...
Critical vulnerability response	< 4 hours to patch or mitigate	From launch
Fake coupon detection rate	> 95% caught before buyer impact	Month 3
Data breach: notification time	< 2 hours to affected users	From launch
Password / auth exposure incidents	Zero	Always

SECTION 13 — POST-LAUNCH ROADMAP & SCALING

13.1 The 18-Month Master Timeline

Milestone	Target Date
Company incorporated + DPIIT registered	Month 1
MVP backend complete (escrow engine, OCR, auth)	Month 2
Android app beta (internal team testing)	Month 3
First 100 real users onboarded (Bengaluru)	Month 3
First 1,000 successful transactions	Month 4
Public launch on Google Play Store	Month 4
iOS App Store launch	Month 6
Seed funding closed	Month 5–7
First 10,000 MAU	Month 7
Dynamic pricing engine V2 live	Month 7
Brand partnerships — first 5 signed	Month 8
Expand to Mumbai, Delhi, Hyderabad	Month 8
50,000 MAU	Month 12
GMV run-rate of ₹1 crore/month	Month 12
ML fraud detection model deployed	Month 12
1,00,000 MAU	Month 15
CouponEx Pro subscription launched	Month 12
Series A fundraise begins	Month 18
Pan-India presence, 5 lakh registered users	Month 18

13.2 Long-Term Product Vision (Year 3–5)

- CouponEx Verified Brand Store: Brands sell their own surplus coupons directly — CouponEx becomes the authorized secondary market for India's biggest brands
- Group Buy Feature: 3–5 users pool their requirements to hit a high minimum-spend coupon collectively, splitting the savings
- Coupon Gifting: Send a coupon as a birthday/occasion gift with a personal message
- CouponEx for Business: B2B tool for small businesses to buy bulk discount coupons to lower operating costs

- International Expansion: Singapore, UAE — large Indian diaspora who use Indian brand apps
- Financial Services Layer: Partner with NBFC for 'buy now, pay via coupon savings later' micro-credit product

13.3 Scaling Checklist (When MAU > 50,000)

- Database: Shard MongoDB cluster, add read replicas for analytics queries
- Backend: Migrate to microservices for escrow, notifications, and search separately
- CDN: Ensure all static assets served from CloudFront edge nodes — Indian regional PoPs
- Queuing: Introduce message queues (AWS SQS/SNS) for notification delivery and payout processing
- Load Testing: Run monthly load tests simulating 5× current peak concurrent users
- Search: Introduce Elasticsearch for fast, faceted coupon search (brand, category, price range, Trust Score)
- Support: Scale to 24/7 coverage with shift-based agents — target 2-hour max first response at all times

13.4 Risk Register

Risk	Mitigation Strategy
Coupon fraud at scale	AI fraud model, AES-256 encryption, T&S team, aggressive ban policy
Razorpay regulatory change (escrow rules)	Legal counsel monitoring, backup PA (Cashfree/PayU) integration ready
Brand blocking CouponEx (cease & desist)	Legal review of coupon resale rights, brand ToS analysis before launch
Low seller supply early on	0% commission for early sellers, referral bonus, college ambassador supply push
Low buyer demand early on	Buyer cashback, aggressive SEO, WhatsApp deal groups seeding
Technical outage during high-traffic event	Blue-green deployment, auto-scaling, 24/7 on-call rotation
Key engineer resignation	Documentation culture, bus factor analysis, cross-training of core systems
Competing platform launches	Speed to market, brand trust moat, first-mover brand recognition
RBI changes to digital payments	Monitor RBI notifications, legal counsel retainer specifically for fintech

13.5 OKR Framework for First Year

Q1 OKRs (Months 1–3)

- Objective: Build a working, trustworthy MVP
 - KR1: 7-step escrow engine functional with < 0.5% transaction failure rate
 - KR2: OCR accuracy above 90% on test set of 500 coupon images
 - KR3: Android app available on internal testing track

Q2 OKRs (Months 4–6)

- Objective: Achieve product-market fit signal in Bengaluru
 - KR1: 1,000 registered users with at least one completed transaction
 - KR2: Day-30 retention above 30%
 - KR3: NPS above 40 from first 100 users surveyed

Q3 OKRs (Months 7–9)

- Objective: Grow GMV and expand geographic reach
 - KR1: ₹25 lakh monthly GMV by Month 9
 - KR2: 10,000 MAU across Bengaluru + Mumbai + Delhi
 - KR3: Seed funding closed — ₹75 lakh+

Q4 OKRs (Months 10–12)

- Objective: Build a sustainable business with repeatable revenue
 - KR1: ₹1 crore monthly GMV run-rate
 - KR2: Platform commission covers 60% of monthly operating costs
 - KR3: 5 brand partnerships active and generating campaign revenue

END OF COUPONEX MASTER OPERATIONS PLAYBOOK

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